

Hybrid Pivot — Self-Serve First, Premium as Upsell

Date: 2026-05-19 (late session)

Decision: Tab confirmed.

Supersedes: parts of STAGE1_LAUNCH_PLAN.md (concierge-only model) and the 3-tier pricing in DECISIONS_LOG.md.

Does NOT replace: PRODUCT_FRAMING.md, BRAND_VOICE_SPEC.md, the IEI Brand System methodology, the legal package, or trademarks. All of that still applies.

What changed and why

Original intent (Tab's words): *"easy-ish build, no-brainer price, for solopreneurs."*

What we drifted into: concierge premium service (Tab in loop for every customer, 3 tiers \$997-\$3,997, 60-min Zoom intake per customer, capped at 4-8 customers/week).

Why the drift was wrong: at \$997 self-serve price, solopreneurs don't expect a Zoom call — they expect a tool. Concierge wrapper made it feel like an agency service, which raises both expectations AND ops cost. Path also caps revenue at Tab's hours.

The pivot: lead with self-serve at \$997 (real no-brainer for solopreneurs), offer premium upgrade (+\$1,000 Brand-Storming with Tab) AFTER delivery. Customer self-selects.

The product, restated

Core offer — Brand Blueprint

\$997 · One-time · Self-serve

What the customer gets:

1. Conversational chat intake (10-20 min, mobile-friendly, "TAB SAYS" voice)
2. AI generates full brand foundation using The IEI Brand System
3. 5 business days later → email delivery with ZIP containing:
 - Brand Playbook (PDF)
 - 3 logo options + brand kit (SVG + PDF)
 - 1-page website (HTML)

- GTM checklist customized to their stated goal
- Brand messaging doc
 1. No Zoom call required. No Tab in loop for the happy path.

Premium upsell — Brand-Storming with Tab

+\$1,000 · Optional · After delivery

In the delivery email: *"Want Tab to personally refine your Blueprint + spend 60 minutes with you on a Brand-Storming call? Upgrade: +\$1,000."*

What they get:

1. 60-min Brand-Storming Zoom call with Tab (uses original intake-call-script.md)
2. Tab manually refines all deliverables based on the call
3. Re-delivery within 3 business days

This is the high-value capture for customers who want the human touch — they SELF-SELECT into it.

Why this is better than either alternative

Vs. concierge-only (\$997-\$3,997 with Tab in every call)	Vs. self-serve-only (\$497 with no Tab option)
✓ Scales beyond Tab's hours	✓ Captures buyers willing to pay for Tab time
✓ Solopreneurs can actually afford it	✓ Higher avg revenue per customer (some take both)
✓ Can run ads / mass outreach	✓ Premium tier becomes the case-study generator
✓ Tab time = paid (only for upgraders)	✓ Tab time goes only where money flows
✗ Some buyers might want Tab from the start	✗ Easier to ship (but loses upsell revenue)

Hybrid = best of both.

The new launch timeline

Was: 5-7 days (concierge MVP — minimal automation needed because Tab did everything manually)

Now: 10-14 days (self-serve MVP — chat UI + Stripe webhook + auto-delivery all become critical path)

Worth it because: self-serve scales infinitely once shipped; concierge caps at Tab's hours.

Week 1 (Days 1-7) — Foundation + start the chat build

Owner	Tasks
Tab	#4 attorney (tonight) · #5 trademarks · #15 domain · #16 video · #17 vocab (URGENT) · #18 visuals (URGENT)
FE Dev	#2 landing site (simplified to 1 tier) · start #8 chat UI
BE Dev	Start #19 chat API · start #21 Stripe webhook · prep #11 SKILL.md changes (waiting on Tab's #17+#18)

Week 2 (Days 8-14) — Wire the automation, ship

Owner	Tasks
Tab	#3 Stripe Payment Links · #13 Notion dashboard · #14 outreach list · #11 SKILL.md goes live (once #17+#18 land)
FE Dev	Finish #8 chat UI · #20 review page (optional v2)
BE Dev	Finish #19 chat API · #22 auto-delivery email + ZIP · #23 premium upgrade flow

Week 3 (Days 15-21) — Test + soft-launch

Owner	Tasks
Tab	#7 end-to-end test with friendly customer · send 20-prospect outreach · first paying customer onboarded
FE Dev	#24 spot-check dashboard
BE Dev	Bug fixes from #7 testing · monitor first real customer flow

Week 4+ (Days 22-30) — Real customers + iteration

Owner	Tasks
Tab	Spot-check 10% of deliveries · capture testimonials · paid ads experiment · start Stage 2 cohort design
Dev team	#9 synthesis bridge (quality leap, now true Days 8-30 work) · #12 types.ts cleanup

Updated success metrics (the buyer-adoption test, sharper)

Old (concierge): 5 happy customers + 2 testimonials in 30 days.

New (self-serve): 30+ customers + 70%+ chat-completion rate + 4+ NPS avg + <10% refund rate in 30 days.

Key new metric: chat-completion rate. If people start the chat but bail, the intake UX is broken. Track religiously.

Premium upgrade conversion target: 15-25% of completed customers upgrade to Brand-Storming (+\$1,000). Conservative: 10%. Optimistic: 30%.

Updated economics

Per-customer math (self-serve only)

- Revenue: \$997
- Stripe fee: ~\$29
- Anthropic API (chat + generation): ~\$1.50
- Email delivery + hosting: ~\$0.10
- Tab time: ~5 min spot-check (1 in 10)
- **Gross margin: ~96%**

Per-customer math (premium upgrade)

- Total revenue: \$1,997
- Stripe fees: ~\$58
- Anthropic API: ~\$2 (refinement adds a bit)
- Tab time: 60-min call + 90 min refinement $\approx$ 2.5 hrs
- **Effective Tab hourly: ~\$400/hr on the upgrade portion**

30-day projection (revised, conservative)

Scenario	Self-serve customers	Premium upgrades	Revenue	Tab hours
Pessimistic	10	1	\$10,970	~5
Realistic	25	4	\$28,925	~15
Optimistic	50	10	\$59,850	~30

Realistic month-1 net: ~\$28K with Tab at 15 hrs/week. Compare to old plan: ~\$11K with Tab at 25 hrs/week. Better revenue AND less Tab time.

Two questions still to lock

1. **Premium upgrade price:** I drafted as +\$1,000 (total \$1,997 if both). Alternatives:
 - +\$497 (total \$1,494) — softer upsell, higher conversion %, lower revenue per - +\$1,500 (total \$2,497) — premium signal, lower conversion %, higher revenue per - +\$1,000 is the safe middle. Stays unless you say otherwise.
 1. **Premium upgrade timing:** I drafted as "in the delivery email." Alternative: also surface as option DURING chat intake ("Want Tab to refine after AI delivers? Add it now for \$X"). Pre-pay vs. post-pay psychology is different.
 - Pre-pay = higher conversion (already in buying mode), customer might not actually need it - Post-pay = lower conversion, but customer KNOWS they need it because they saw the AI output first - I'd recommend POST-PAY (after delivery) — feels less salesy + customer trusts you after seeing real work. But pre-pay would print more revenue per customer.
- Default for now: **+\$1,000 post-pay only**. Flag if you'd change.
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What didn't change

- The IEI Brand System methodology (still the spine)
 - Tab's voice + proprietary phrases (still the AI's voice)
 - Legal package (TOS + Privacy + IP Clickthrough cover both flows)
 - Trademark filings (Brand Blueprint + IEI Ventures)
 - Domain strategy (ieiventures.com/blueprint + register brandblueprint.com)
 - Brand-playbook skill + SKILL_UPDATE.md edits (more urgent now, same content)
 - Tab's \$550/hr 1:1 consulting (still exists separately, premium upgrade is its productized cousin)
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